

“ PEOPLE WILL REJECT THE CAMPAIGN FOR FORCING THE STATE INTO NARROW CONFINES OF THE MARATHI *MANOOS*. ”

NIKHIL KUMAR, CONGRESS MP FROM AURANGABAD



RANJAN RAHI

BHASKAR PAUL



“ THE ISSUE OF PRIORITY FOR LOCALS IS A SENSITIVE ONE AND WE MUST ADDRESS IT WITHOUT HURTING ANYONE'S FEELINGS. ”

SUPRIYA SULE, NCP MP

the two ruling coalition partners are constantly trying to outdo each other. The situation was tailor-made for the opportunistic Raj to play with fire to carve out his own niche. When he started taunting the 'outsiders', Mumbai's ruling class looked the other way. When aspirants for railway jobs were beaten up and prevented from taking examinations, Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh initially seemed to view it as a problem that would go away on its own. But when the pressure got on him, he finally decided to book Raj under Section 153 of the IPC, which ensured that the MNS chief was out of jail within 24 hours. It was a familiar compromise. Raj could have easily been booked for more serious offences which would have ensured a longer stay in jail. A Bombay High Court judge, Justice J.N. Patel, had already condemned his actions and likened him to a terrorist. There was also a case pending against him in Jamshedpur, where a non-bailable warrant had been issued against him for denigrating a community (Biharis). Instead, there was shameful capitulation from all concerned, an indication of the psychological blow that one man and his rabid followers have inflicted on India's maximum city.

The police cannot be expected to do any better when Joint Commissioner of Police K.L. Prasad, who showed spine by reminding Raj that Mumbai was not anyone's ancestral property, is told to lie low. And when the nation expected its leaders to act decisively, nothing was forthcoming from those who mattered. The silence from Congress President Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi was sphinx-like, while Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's call for sanity

seemed under duress, coming as it did after the unlikely combine of Railways Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav, Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and Steel Minister Ram Vilas Paswan lodged protests. Many feel that it is Lalu's style of politics that may have enraged the MNS leader. After all, he had provoked the MNS activists by announcing that he would perform Chhath Puja in Mumbai. Worse, his ministry conducted the railway recruitment examinations in Mumbai without advertising the vacancies in Marathi papers.

Raj, whose MNS failed to save either its honour or its deposit in several local elections, couldn't have asked for anything better. With less than 2,000 cadre, of whom at best 500 can be said to be hardcore, he had the media and even big business eat out of his hands. It was Naresh Goyal of Jet Airways who propelled Raj to greater glory by rescinding the sacking of nearly 2,000 airline employees after he threatened to stop Jet Airways flights in and out of Mumbai. The silence of the political class and civil society to his uncivil ways, coupled with the total absence of professional protesters among Mumbai's out-of-work film directors and actors meant Raj was



RAMPAGE : MNS workers damaged buses and other public property in Mumbai